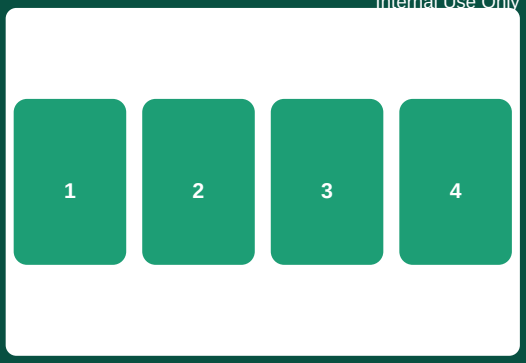
QUALITY & PROCESS

Internal Use Only

5 Why's

Drill down to root cause by repeatedly asking 'Why?' — typically five times — until the underlying, actionable cause is



WHEN TO USE

For any problem where the immediate cause is visible but the root cause (the one you can actually prevent) is not.

HOW TO APPLY — STEPS

1. State the problem clearly, specifically, and quantifiably
2. Ask Why it occurred and record the answer as a fact
3. Ask Why again about that answer
4. Repeat until you reach a cause you can act on at the system level
5. Verify: if fixing this root cause would prevent the problem recurring, you are done

PRACTITIONER TIP

! Each Why must be causally linked to the previous one. If you cannot draw a cause-effect chain, your analysis has gone wrong.

KEY OUTPUTS

- 5 Why's chain diagram or table
- Root cause statement
- Corrective action with verification date

HOW TO MEASURE SUCCESS

Problem recurrence rate at 30 and 90 days; time from detection to root cause identified

TOOL CATEGORY

Quality & Process